

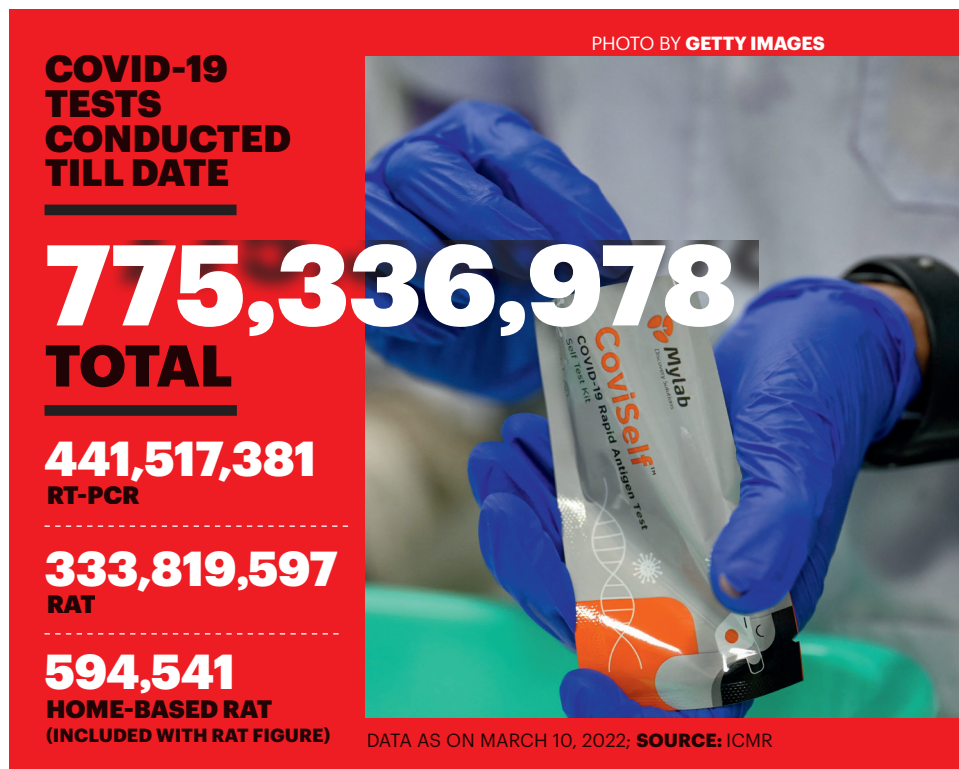
home testing picked up fast, some states and districts recorded a decrease in Covid-19 testing in parallel, possibly as an outcome of the rise in home testing, which is difficult to record officially. “Home testing is increasing globally, and also in India, due to the ease of performing it in the safety of one’s home, instant result availability, repeatability, and ready availability at the nearest chemist,” explains Dr Harsh Mahajan, Founder of Mahajan Imaging, a diagnostic imaging centre in Delhi.

An Emerging Business

From the baseline demand of a few thousand kits, Mylab has witnessed a jump in sales of almost 500 per cent of its self-test kit—CoviSelf—since December 2021. Hasmukh Rawal, MD and Co-founder, Mylab Discovery Solutions, says this surge is because of supply and demand side forces. “The customer needs an instant test at low cost as soon as symptoms show up, without stepping out. RT-PCR labs, on the other hand, are not able to handle the increasing volume of tests,” he says, adding that the market will expand as schools, colleges and offices re-open. “The market for self-test kits will grow at least for the next two years,” says Rawal.

But there’s a catch. According to industry experts, RT-PCR has 100 per cent accuracy as it uses a molecular technique that is the gold standard in diagnostics. RAT kits are 70-80 per cent accurate, but when positivity rates are high, they are still very useful because when a rapid test shows you as positive, it is certain to be positive.

Tata Medical and Diagnostics’ RAT kit is slightly more advanced—it can detect both Delta and Omicron variants. “Along with Tata MD’s Express PCR instrument, the kit is able to provide quick PCR



reports at a large scale. It is ideal for locations like airports, hospitals, and events where gold-standard accuracy is required with quick results,” says Dr V. Ravi, Head, R&D at Tata Medical and Diagnostics.

Trivitron Healthcare’s Covid-19 self-test kit has recently been validated by the ICMR. Chandra Ganjoo, Executive Director of Trivitron, says the rising demand for antibody tests is expected to drive the market for Covid-19 RAT kits. “These rapid test kits will be shaping and changing our lives over the coming years,”

says Ganjoo, adding that even if new Covid-19 variants were to emerge, self-test kits would flourish, become cheaper and ubiquitous like home pregnancy tests. She says home testing kits are portable, reliable, easy to administer, and more economical than laboratory-based tests, enabling countries to increase the pace of testing, tracing, and treating people particularly in small towns and villages where the healthcare system is under-resourced.

The big challenge wrought by self-test kits is the under-reporting of Covid-19 cases. “Our test kits have a mechanism by which the suspected patient can intimate their status on our mobile application by just uploading the picture of their reports, which is then sent to the ICMR portal,” says Rawal. Meanwhile, the Food and Drugs Authority (FDA) divisions of several states have asked manufacturers, distribu-

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PER CENT

SENSITIVITY OF PANBIO COVID-19 ANTIGEN SELF-TEST, ONE OF THE LATEST HOME-BASED TESTING KITS BY ABBOTT